

Chapter - 1

The Anguish of the Sage-Hermitages

The Rise of Ravana and the Tale of a Hermitage - When Even Patience Is Tested

Work: Sitayan (Through Mother Sita's Eyes) · Series: Shri Adishakti Mahakosh · Author: Adishakti Bhagwati Maa Ambe (Servant - Suraj Kumar Lohani)

By Maa's grace the servant - Maa's own work - Maa's own glory.

Invocation

तपसा क्षीयते पापं तपसा वर्धते बलम्।
तपस्विनां न विघ्नोऽस्ति यत्र धर्मः प्रतिष्ठितः॥

Meaning - By austerity sin is destroyed, by austerity strength increases — where righteousness (dharma) is established, no obstacle can permanently hinder those devoted to austerity (tapasvis).

The Rise of Lanka — When Pride Crossed All Bounds

This was a time when Ravana's strength had not yet reached its zenith, but its shadow had already begun to spread across the world. Born in the lineage of Pulastya, Ravana, son of Vishrava, was extraordinary both in austerity and in scriptural learning. Through years of severe penance he had won a boon from Lord Brahma that no god, demon, gandharva, or yaksha could slay him. This boon granted him immense power, but along with it, it also sowed within him a pride that gradually began to cloud his intellect.

In Lanka, his golden palaces gleamed in the rays of the sun. Pillars set with gems, chambers ablaze with jewel-lamps, and all around such splendor of prosperity that any onlooker would stand astonished. Yet within that brilliance a darkness was quietly growing, one that even Ravana himself could not recognize — he had forgotten that power is granted for the service of dharma, not for the satisfaction of ego.

First he attacked the realm of the Gandharvas and brought them under his sway. Then he marched upon the city of the Yakshas, seizing both Lanka and the Pushpaka Vimana (celestial chariot) from his own half-brother, Kubera. Then he defeated the Kinnaras. And with every victory his arrogance rose to a new height, like a river that flows unchecked once its dam has broken. His campaign of conquest now turned, brushing against the boundaries of the celestial realm, toward the peaceful hermitages of the sages and seers upon the earth.

Ravana's Court — A Scene at Evening

One evening, in Lanka's golden chamber, Ravana was listening to an account of his campaigns of conquest. Ministers, generals, kinsmen and brothers — all were immersed in praising him. But in one corner sat the minister Maricha, silent, a line of worry in his eyes that no one else could see.

In Ravana's Court — Pride and Warning

Senapati (Commander) (with enthusiasm) - Maharaja, today even the realm of the Gandharvas has accepted your dominion. Now there is none in all the three worlds who does not bow his head before you.

Ravana (laughing with pride) - This is exactly as it should be. Who can possibly stop one who has received from Lord Brahma the boon that neither gods nor demons can slay him?

Maricha (softly, with humility) - Maharaja, when you asked for the boon, you made no mention of man or vanara (monkey) — I wish humbly to remind you of this.

Ravana (laughing in mockery) - Man? Vanara? Maricha, what strange talk is this. What harm could a mere man possibly do to me? It is as though an ant were to challenge an elephant.

Maricha (to himself, remaining silent) - Maharaja, arrogance is the very eye that makes even the greatest danger appear trivial. I fear that this same mistake will one day become the cause of your destruction.

The Nature of Ravana's Conquest

Ravana was not merely a warrior — he was also a scholar, versed in all four Vedas, a supreme devotee of Shiva, accomplished in both music and scripture. This is precisely why his fall appears so tragic — because a man possessed of such capacity to establish dharma turned that very capacity into a servant of destruction.

In his army was a brother as mighty as Kumbhakarna, a son as valiant as Indrajit, and many powerful aides such as Maricha, Subahu, Khara, and Dushana. Intoxicated by the pride of this vast might, he had ceased even to consider that anyone could stop him.

Power and Dharma

शक्तिः धर्मपरित्यक्ता विनाशाय न संशयः।

यो बलं धर्महीनं तु स नैव सुखमश्नुते॥

Meaning - Power devoid of dharma is, without doubt, destined for destruction — the strength that lacks righteousness never attains true happiness.

And now, sunk in this pride, Ravana's gaze slowly began to turn toward Dandakaranya — toward that land where hundreds of sages and seers were peacefully performing austerities, unaware that a great shadow was about to loom over their peace.

The Hermitage of Sharabhanga — A Tranquil Dawn

At one edge of Dandakaranya, on the bank of a tributary of the Godavari, stood the hermitage of the great sage Sharabhanga. Here, every morning, the same scene would unfold — smoke rising from the sacrificial fire-pit (havan-kund), the echo of chanted mantras, and deer that would come fearlessly close even to the sage-maidens. This hermitage was not merely a place of austerity — it was a living example of how dharma and nature could dwell together.

The great sage Sharabhanga himself had remained steadfast in a single vow for years. His wife and disciples remained devoted to his service — one would bring fruit, another would fetch water, another would recite the Vedas. This life was hard, but within it lay a deep peace, for every tapasvi (ascetic) knew — this path had been chosen by their own free will.

There was a young disciple in the hermitage named Suvrata. Every morning he would rise first of all to kindle the fire of the havan-kund, then fetch water from the Godavari. In his eyes was that devotion found only in a soul raised from childhood in service to the guru. He would often ask the great sage — 'Gurudev, can our austerity ever go in vain?' And the sage would always answer, smiling — 'Austerity never goes to waste, my child. Sometimes its fruit does not come at once, but it keeps accumulating, until the time is ripe.'

The First Shadow

But for some months now — something had changed. Sometimes at night, distant screams would be heard. Sometimes, on looking in the morning, it would be found that the fence of some nearby smaller hermitage lay broken, its offerings for the fire scattered about. Small bands of rakshasas (demons) had now begun roaming openly, as though they feared no one at all.

The great sage Sharabhanga had told his disciples — 'Have patience. This too is a test. Austerity never goes to waste.' But deep within, they too knew that this shadow was growing darker. One night Suvrata had asked his guru's wife — 'Mother,

should we be afraid?' And the guru's wife, placing her hand upon his head, had said — 'Not fear, my child, but vigilance. Fear makes us weak; vigilance keeps us prepared.'

The Test of Patience

धैर्यं यस्य न शीर्यते विपदि प्राप्तेऽपि सर्वथा।

स एव तपसां भागी परं धाम स गच्छति॥

Meaning - One whose patience never wavers in any way even when calamity comes — he alone is the true tapasvi, he alone attains the supreme abode.

That Night — When the Line Was Crossed

One night — a full-moon night, when ordinarily a special havan would be held at the hermitage — a large band of rakshasas arrived near the hermitage. At their head was a rakshasa who had come bearing a direct order from Ravana's court — to warn all the hermitages of Dandakaranya that they must either accept the dominion of Lanka, or face destruction.

Fear spread among the sage-maidens. Small children clung to their mothers. Suvrata came running to his guru and said — 'Gurudev, they have come! That very shadow we feared!' But the great sage Sharabhanga stood calm — in his hand was neither weapon nor fear.

The Dialogue Between Sharabhanga and His Wife

Wife (in a frightened voice) - My lord, these people will not spare even our children. Please tell me, what should we do now?

Maharishi Sharabhanga (with calm resolve) - Devi, do not be afraid. The one who has given us this austerity will also protect us. But today I feel — this suffering is no longer ours alone.

Wife - What do you mean?

Maharishi Sharabhanga - This suffering has now grown so vast that its answer will come not through human austerity, but through the very descent of the Lord Himself. Tonight I saw a sign in the sky — the gods are in council.

Suvrata (in a trembling voice, coming closer) - Gurudev, will all of us remain safe?

Maharishi Sharabhanga (placing his hand on his head, with affection) - My child, one who has taken refuge in austerity is never truly unsafe, even if tonight brings suffering to endure. Remember — this night too shall pass, and behind it lies hidden a great dawn.

Sharabhanga's Prayer

न मे भयं राक्षसेभ्यो न मृत्योर्न च कर्मणः।

एकं भयं जगन्नाथ त्वद्भक्तानां विनाशनम्॥

Meaning - O Lord of the universe (Jagannatha), I fear neither the rakshasas, nor death, nor karma — I have but one fear, the destruction of your devotees.

Warning and Departure

That night the band of rakshasas did cause harm to the hermitage — they broke some huts, scattered the offerings for the fire — but by the power of Maharishi Sharabhanga's austerity, they could not take the life of any being, and after delivering their warning, they departed. But that night became a turning point for the hermitage.

The very next day, Maharishi Sharabhanga decided that he himself would meet with the other sages and send forth a united call — not only for his own hermitage, but for all the ascetics of the whole of Dandakaranya. Suvrata asked — 'Gurudev, will a call really change anything?' The sage answered — 'My child, a true call never goes in vain. It travels faster even than the speed of light, and it surely reaches the right heart.'

The Sages' United Call

Many sages connected to the disciple-lineages of Agastya, Atri, and Vasishtha gathered together. Together they composed a hymn of praise and sent it skyward through the sacrificial fire — believing that this call would surely reach some divine ear.

And that call did indeed reach — the heart of Mother Earth (Bhoomi Devi), who was already grief-stricken, and now, hearing this collective voice, her resolve grew firmer still that she herself would go to Vaikuntha.

A Disciple's Anguish — In the Night at the Hermitage

That night, when everyone had gone to sleep, Suvrata sat alone at the hermitage gate, gazing at the sky. In his mind a question kept rising again and again — 'Is anyone truly listening to our call?' Just then the guru's wife came and sat beside him.

Suwrata and the Guru's Wife — A Night Conversation

Suwrata (softly) - Mother, sometimes it feels as though the sky is silent. Does our call get lost somewhere?

Guru's Wife (stroking his head) - My child, the sky is never silent. We simply do not recognize the language of its answer. Sometimes the answer comes as a cloud, sometimes as the wind, and sometimes — on some day — as a human being.

Suwrata (in astonishment) - As a human being? What do you mean, Mother?

Guru's Wife (looking toward the sky, smiling) - My child, Gurudev says that when suffering becomes boundless, the Supreme Being Himself takes human form and comes. Perhaps that day is not far off.

The Hermitage's Night Prayer

रक्षन्तु नः तपोवीर्यं देवाः सर्वे समाहिताः।

अन्धकारे अपि दीपः स्यात् आशाया एष सम्भवः॥

Meaning - May all the gods, united in concentration, protect the strength of our austerity — even in darkness may there be a lamp; herein lies the very possibility of hope.

The Message of Sharabhanga's Hermitage

Austerity never loses — it only waits, for the right time



This night at Sharabhanga's hermitage was not alone in its kind. Similar screams, similar warnings, were rising at that very time from many other hermitages across Dandakaranya. And this collective call — which had just gone skyward from the sacrificial fire — was now about to reach a heart far greater still, whose patience was already on the verge of breaking. That same night, on the bank of another tributary of the Godavari, a fire was burning in yet another hermitage — and the tale of that place was yet to unfold.

Summary

This chapter first describes the rise of Ravana, his boon, his campaign of conquest, and the arrogance growing within him, which is also shown through a scene in his own court, where he mocks away the warning of his minister Maricha. Thereafter, through the tale of Maharishi Sharabhanga's hermitage, the chapter shows the rising demonic atrocities upon the sages of Dandakaranya. On a full-moon night, a band of rakshasas raids the hermitage, but through the power of the sage's austerity, no great harm occurs. Inspired by this event, Sharabhanga joins with other sages to send forth a united prayer, which reaches the heart of Mother Earth and brings her patience to the very brink of breaking. At the end of the chapter comes the hint that this suffering was not confined to one hermitage, but had spread across the whole of Dandakaranya.

Thus ends Kanda 1 — The Divine Resolve

Chapter One — Complete

The Servant's Perspective

This pride of Ravana's — that "what harm could a mere man possibly do to me" — reminds me that the greatest downfall in life begins the very moment we start believing our own strength to be our own possession, forgetting that every power is a gift bestowed by some greater authority. That silent fear of Maricha's, which he could not bring himself to voice, also teaches me that one must have the courage to speak the truth, no matter how powerful the listener may be. And this sentiment of Maharishi Sharabhanga's — "I have no fear of my own destruction; my fear is for the destruction of the devotees" — shakes me deeply. When I too face difficulties in life — whether my own or those of my loved ones — I try to learn this very lesson: that fear should not be for oneself, but a rightful concern for the protection of dharma and family. And also that austerity and prayer never go in vain — even if the answer does not come at once, Mother Ambe surely listens in her own time. In my own daily sadhana too, I hold this same feeling — constant, without concern for the fruit, surrendered at Mother's feet. — Suraj Kumar Lohani · An offering (nimitta) to Adishakti Bhagwati Maa Ambe. ॐ नमो श्री भगवती जगदम्बिके दुर्गायै नमः॥

Shri Adishakti Mahakosh

Khand 1 - The Divine Resolve

Chapter - 2

The Weeping of Mother Earth

The Earth Tormented by Ravana's Tyranny - Background to a Great Resolve

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By Maa's grace the servant - Maa's own work - Maa's own glory.

Invocation

धरा रुरोद दुःखार्ता रावणस्य बलात् तदा।
आदिशक्तेः अंशभूता सा हि सर्वसहा सदा॥

Meaning - At that time, tormented by Ravana's tyranny, the Earth wept in sorrow — that Earth who is herself a portion of the Adishakti (Primordial Divine Power), who ever endures all things.

Another Such Night — When the Sacrificial Fire Was Extinguished

Sharabhanga's hermitage was not alone in passing through this suffering. That same night, at another edge of Dandakaranya, on the bank of a tributary of the Godavari, stood the hermitage of another tapasvi (ascetic) — just such a living example of how dharma and nature could dwell together. Every morning the same scene would unfold there — fragrant smoke rising from the havan-kund (sacrificial fire-pit), the echo of Vedic chants reaching to the branches of the trees, and deer that would fearlessly graze on grass from the very hands of the sage-maidens.

That evening too had begun like any ordinary day. The sun was setting, the sky was dyed saffron, and within the hermitage the sound of the evening prayers (sandhya-vandana) was echoing. But into that peace a heavy silence suddenly descended — the birds ceased their chirping, the wind grew still, as though nature herself had sensed the approach of some calamity.

Then, from afar, the sound of footsteps was heard — heavy, irregular, many. And before their very eyes, a band of rakshasas came to stand at the boundary of the hermitage. At their head was that same rakshasa who had come bearing a direct order from Lanka's court — to proclaim to every hermitage of Dandakaranya the warning that they must either accept the dominion of Lanka, or else prepare for destruction.

The havan-kund was kicked and extinguished. The sacrificial offerings were scattered. The sage-maidens cried out in fear, the children hid in their mothers' laps. The elder ascetics who came forward to intervene were shoved aside, and some were taken captive. That night, which had ever been witness only to peace and the chanting of mantras, became instead a witness to weeping and terror.